



Sweet FM

An open source client for last.fm allows for much better functionality, such as station shuffle, superior album art, and remote control support



The origins

This new wave began sometime in the mid-80s when Richard Stallman quit his job at MIT and set up the Free Software Foundation. His belief was simple – create high quality software that is freely available to everybody. But what was wrong with corporations making software back then? Commercial companies constrict their software with patents and copyrights and keep the source code—the original program code, a closely guarded secret. Even the processes and approaches to doing things were locked away, and many developers found themselves stifled and shackled. Software thus being created was not of the best possible quality and definitely poorer than what could've been achieved through collaboration. There was no free flow of ideas, and if programmers had no way to learn from previously written code, the art of programming was likely to stagnate.

Folklore attributes the turning point in this revolution to one fateful day when Stallman wanted to modify the source code of a printer to make it perform a specific function, but was denied the right to do so. In an interview he says, “The issue with the printer was that I wanted to make it possible for the system to notify users when a job was printed, or if the printer was in trouble. That would have allowed people to go and collect their output only when it was complete, rather than having to guess.” To do so, Stallman needed the printer's source code, which was denied on the grounds that it was proprietary information – making him “very angry”.

Eventually, the internet ushered in the era of collaboration, sharing, the free flow of information and the modular approach to working on projects. Stallman, however, later became a proponent of the free software movement, that believes in complete freedom, while the culture that has evolved over time is about cultural openness rather than strictly open source.

The culture of the masses

Perhaps Wikipedia is the quintessential open philosophy project. This form of open philosophy later became known as crowdsourcing. The collaboration success story is a massive endeavour driven by a legion of contributors who work for nothing more than a desire to disseminate accurate information. The web site has close to 10 million registered users, many of whom not only use it as a resource, but also contribute towards expanding it.

People are increasingly using the internet and contributing in their own little way to many such projects

that run on the open source mantra. Under the provisions of the Creative Commons licence, creators can put up their work on a platter for anyone to comment on, improve, modify and use, if they so wish. Flickr.com at last count had some

2 billion pictures (in November 2007) and has been growing steadily since then at the rate of about five million photos a day! The better works amongst them (that are released into the public domain) are finding their way into popular culture to be forever immortalised. The recent album cover of a quite well known indie band, Bon Iver, is an arresting picture of an object almost completely submerged under thick snow. The image didn't come from one of those great artists of yesteryear who designed the cover art for albums like Dark Side of the Moon. Instead it came from the flickr posts of Lauren Hudgins, a nondescript English teacher living in Japan.

Open source journalism

Instances of the culture can be found even in mass media. Earlier, the power to publish was in the hands of a few. With platforms

Where the traditional way of doing things was to closely guard the building blocks to a product the new way is to open everything to the community, resulting in the obvious outcome – collaboration leading to a much better product

such as blogs coming into existence, that allow for push button publishing, citizen journalism is on the rise. Now, these may not necessarily be open source in the literal sense; they are however tools that facilitate cultural openness and freedom. Tools such as these have helped deliver news at some very critical times. The source of such news is completely open, ie. it comes from the global collective. For instance,

mainstream publications such as the New York Times picked up news trickling out of Iran via twitter. The news was modified, pieced together to join the dots and made into a meaningful picture of events, before being published – all this involves the fundamental tenets of open source – collaboration, modification, and freedom.

But for reasons that are somewhat justified, bloggers and citizen journalists are not highly regarded as far as news value is concerned. The concerns are mainly about accuracy of their sources. Yet, there are several benefits that greatly outweigh these flaws. For instance, open journalism will take up causes that news corporations will be extremely reluctant to tackle; vested interests and controversy always get in the way. But speaking of quality there are web sites that get their content from the open world but adhere

to internationally accepted reporting standards. The content that they receive is vetted, edited and modified. Editorialised web sites like globalvoicesonline.org, backed by Harvard Law, is one such example. This phenomenon is also called crowdsourced journalism and nowpublic.com is regarded as the leader in this field. “NowPublic is a participatory news network which mobilizes an army of reporters to cover the events

that define our world. In twelve short months, the company has become one of the fastest growing news organizations with thousands of reporters in over 140 countries”, says the award winning web site. Now it will take some time before such blog-based web sites become a mass culture since no single blog post will get as much coverage as, say, an article on the front page of a national daily. But it's culture driven by the masses.

Several companies have taken to crowdsourcing their research & development. Even the

PROSUMERISM

An offshoot of the open source movement is the rise of the prosumer. A prosumer can mean several things. One is a mixture of a professional and consumer. In this capacity the prosumer is viewed as a segment by marketers and generally refers to a discerning, or high-end consumer. The other meaning is derived from the mashup of a producer and a consumer. This definition is more in line with the open source philosophy. The prosumer thus is a consumer who takes part in the production of a product, instead of the traditional passive role that he was expected to play earlier. With the rise of mechanisms for collecting consumer opinions through the internet, consumers can now influence the research and development (R&D) of a product. Companies pay special attention to the needs of customers and make products to fit those needs. This participative form of product development is derived from the FOSS movement.